Introduction

Reinventing Management

From Extractive to Regenerative · From Resource to Source · From BUSYness to High Performance

Much of what we have been taught about management rests on an unexamined assumption.

Not a malicious lie. Not a conscious one. But a lie so embedded in the foundations of modern organisations that most leaders have never once thought to question it. It feels true. It sounds sensible. It gets passed from business school to boardroom to performance review without anyone stopping to ask whether it is actually right.

Here it is:

"The purpose of management is to use resources smartly to get maximum output."

Strip away every framework, every model, every theory produced in the last hundred years of management thinking, and you will find this assumption sitting at the centre of all of it. Undisturbed. Unquestioned. Treated as an obvious, no-need-to-discuss kind of truth.

The pages that follow ask you to question it.

The Extractive Century

For one hundred years, management has been fundamentally extractive. Everything, without exception, has been treated as a resource to be optimised, leveraged, and consumed in the pursuit of output. Land. Capital. Technology. Time. Nature. And most devastatingly, people.

Notice the word itself. *Human resources*. Not human beings. Not human sources of creativity, wisdom, passion, and purpose. Resources. To be allocated. Utilised. And when no longer productive, replaced.

And like all mining, extractive management produces remarkable results in the short term. Seams of value are opened. Output surges. Metrics improve. Shareholders celebrate. And all the while, beneath the surface, the ground is hollowing out.

The hollowing out shows up first in the people. A quiet withdrawal of energy. A narrowing of contribution. A decision, made not in a boardroom but in the privacy of a human soul, to give less. To risk

less. To care less. Because caring fully in an extractive system is not rewarded — it is consumed.

Then it moves to culture. Then to results. And then, the inevitable consequence of one hundred years of extractive management, the bill arrives.

Key Finding	Source
Global employee engagement has fallen to 21%. This costs the global economy $438 billion in direct productivity loss. The full cost — including disengagement's drag on innovation, quality, and retention — reaches $8.8 trillion annually: approximately 9% of global GDP.	*Gallup, State of the Global Workplace 2023/24 and 2025*
Even high-performing companies deliver ~30% less value than their strategies promise, largely due to cultural and execution gaps.	*McKinsey & Company*
INDIA: Gallup's India research puts employee engagement at approximately 14% — one of the lowest rates among major economies, with the associated productivity cost estimated in the trillions of dollars annually.	*Gallup India Workplace Survey, 2023*
ASIA: Across Asia-Pacific, only 16% of workers are highly engaged, while 31% are actively disengaged.	*ADP Research Institute, People at Work 2024*

In an extractive system, the fundamental question is always the same: How do we get more out of what we have? This is not management. This is mining.

Now, that has become the DNA of how almost everyone thinks. We, the leaders, have created this egocentric organisational and societal culture.

The Three Silences

In every organisation that has lost its way, three silences appear — slowly, devastatingly, almost invisibly.

The Silence of the Soul.

The soul is not interested in a number game. The soul is only interested in purpose. Without it, organisations become technically functioning and spiritually empty — busy without meaning, active without direction, successful without significance. The people show up. They complete tasks. They hit some of the numbers. But something is gone. The energy has left the room. The spirit has left the room. And BUSYness rushes in to fill the void.

The Silence of the Heart.

People don't bring their hearts to work because they have learned it is not safe. The heart withdraws steadily, one disappointment at a time, until the person sitting across from you is emotionally absent. Present in body, absent in spirit. And with them goes the creativity, the courage, and the real care that no management system can manufacture. You can measure engagement scores, but you cannot manufacture what is left when the heart is sent away.

The Silence of the Head.

The greatest waste in any organisation is not financial — it is intellectual. Ideas withheld. Solutions unoffered. Innovations never attempted. All silenced by a philosophy designed to extract compliance, not unlock wisdom. Look around your next meeting. Count the people who are genuinely contributing versus those who are physically present and mentally somewhere else entirely.

Three silences. Soul. Heart. Head. And in their absence, BUSYness rushes in to fill the void.

The Fundamental Shift

Regenerative Management is not a softer version of management. It is not management with better values. It is a fundamentally different operating philosophy — one that produces fundamentally different results.

Extractive Management	→	Regenerative Management
Everything is a Resource; use it.	Everything is a Source; partner with it.	
Extract maximum output	Multiply potential over time.	
Control and manage behaviour	Trust and develop capability.	

Extractive Management	→	Regenerative Management
Short-term performance focus	Long-term legacy building	
Produces BUSYness	Produces High Performance	

The shift is not semantic. It is structural.

When you treat a person as a resource, the question you bring to every interaction is: *What can I get from this person?*

When you treat them as a source, the question changes: *What is possible through this person that hasn't yet been discovered?*

Those two questions produce fundamentally different organisations.

The ROAR Model

The journey follows a model. Four words. One journey. One decision that must be made before anything else can follow.

R, Reflect.

Reflect ruthlessly. Confront the BUSYness you have created. Not the BUSYness around you — the BUSYness you have allowed, normalised, and in many cases personally generated.

O, Own.

Own the reality of your organisation without excuses. Without transferring blame to the market, the economy, your people, or your competitors. The organisation you lead is the organisation you have built. That is both the hardest truth and the most empowering one.

A, Assert.

Assert non-negotiable standards — first in yourself, Then, and only then, in every person and every room. You cannot hold others to a standard you haven't first modelled.

R, Run.

Run at High Performance, relentlessly and without looking back. This is not a one-time programme. It is a permanent way of operating.

The journey begins not with a plan — but with a mirror.

Exercises — Introduction: Reinventing Management

This introduction is not asking you to improve a few methods. It is asking you to confront the philosophy beneath those methods. Do not move into Chapter 1 with admiration for the ideas. Move with a philosophy you are now prepared to live.

Exercise 1: The Inherited Assumptions

— Which assumption about growth or performance has your organisation been treating as truth simply because it inherited it?

— Which assumption about people has your organisation been treating as truth simply because it inherited it?

— Where is that assumption most apparent — in targets, incentives, policies, meetings, or leadership language?

— If those assumptions were false, what would need to change immediately?

Exercise 2: The Extractive Audit

— Where are people being optimised instead of developed?

— Where are customers being transacted with instead of being understood in depth?

— Where are short-term results consuming long-term capability?

— What am I treating as a Resource in my organisation that I should be treating as a Source?

Write it plainly. The gap between how you see people and what they could contribute is the single largest untapped resource your organisation has.

Exercise 3: The Regenerative Choice

— Complete this sentence: *"The quality of life our organisation exists to improve is _____."*

— Name one long-term, multi-year capability you must start building now.

— Which of the Three Silences — Soul, Heart, or Head — is most present in your organisation right now? What evidence do you see?

The Regenerative shift doesn't begin in a workshop. It begins the moment a leader decides to stop asking "How do I get more out of

what I have?" and starts asking "What can I co-create with people as my partners?" That question changes everything.

R | *Reflect*

Confront the BUSYness you have created.